

For the better part of thirty years now, Newman has been in and out of some of the toughest prisons in the Midwest. Not, of course, as an inmate, but as one of the world's most intrepid researchers, working with psychopaths high above the snow line of dysfunction. Though long since acclimated to the harsh, unforgiving conditions, he concedes there are times, even now, when it all gets a little bit hairy.

He recalls, for example, an incident that occurred a few years back with a guy who scored 40 on the PCL-R. That, if you recall, is the maximum you can get. And it's rare. The guy was a "pure" psychopath. "Usually there's a point in the interview where we like to push people a little bit," Newman tells me. "You know, challenge them. Gauge their reaction. But when we did that with this fella—and he was a really nice guy up until then: charming, funny, big personality—he got this kind of cold, derelict look in his eyes, difficult to describe, but you know it when you see it, which just seemed to say, 'Back off!' And you know what? We did! He scared the absolute shit out of us."

Newman, by his own admission, sometimes gets that look in his own eyes. He stops short of saying that it takes one to know one. But growing up as a kid on the mean streets of New York, he's had knives, and guns, and the whole nine yards pulled on him. Without a trace of irony, he's grateful, he says. It was a taste of things to come. In academia.

Newman is more abstemious than most when it comes to the selection criteria for a psychopath. "My main concern is that the label [of psychopath] is applied too liberally, and without sufficient understanding of the key elements," he purrs in a soft, almost apologetic tone. "As a result, the doors are thrown open to pretty much anyone, and the term is often applied to ordinary criminals and sex offenders whose behavior may reflect primarily social factors or other emotional problems that are more responsive to treatment than psychopathy."

Similarly, he's more than amenable to the idea of psychopaths coexisting outside the criminal firmament, often doing very well for themselves in professions that might otherwise come as a surprise to those less well versed in the building blocks of the psychopathic personality: as surgeons, lawyers, and corporate head honchos, for example. "The combination of low risk aversion and lack of guilt or remorse, the two central pillars of